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Clay Jenkins

Clay Jenkins has fashioned a successful career as a jazz performer and educator. Clay has been a member of bands led by Stan Kenton, Count Basie and Buddy Rich and currently plays in the trumpet section of the Clayton-Hamilton Jazz Orchestra. In 2000 he joined the faculty of the Eastman School of Music Jazz Department. Clay maintains a robust performing schedule and records with jazz artists such as Gene Bertoncini, Kim Richmond and Joe LaBarbera.

Clay was interviewed at Hamilton College on March 18, 2016 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and we are in the Jazz Archive at Hamilton College, and I'm pleased to have Clay Jenkins with me today. And I'm wondering, if you go to a cocktail party and nobody knows who you are, and they say, "so what do you do?" What's your short answer?

CJ: I would say, "well I'm a jazz musician and I teach at a conservatory in New York called the Eastman School of Music. That's what I usually would say.

MR: So you say you are a jazz musician first?

CJ: Yes. And though I love my teaching and I love Eastman and I love my colleagues and I love my students, and I really hold it in high regard in terms of my musicianship, because it's been really good for me being there. I've learned so much from my colleagues and guests, and the students. So I feel like a student there. But yeah, I mean I know that my playing career will probably last longer than my teaching career, which is not the same with everybody.

MR: You think your playing career will last longer than your teaching career?

CJ: I think so, yeah.

MR: Okay. Because I would not have been surprised if you said the opposite.

CJ: I know. But well we were just talking about Joe Wilder. And I was introduced to him by Snooky Young. And Snooky and I were together in the Clayton-Hamilton band for 26 years. And he lived to be 90. He played until he passed away. And I just saw how young it kept him. And my dad played and it kept him young. Unless I get to where I can't play very well you know. But I still feel like I'm really sort of — I feel like there's a lot more music I want to write and a lot more music I want to play. And I don't know where I'll be. I may be on the west coast or I may be in New York, I don't know where I'll be. But I do feel like I'll be playing.

MR: Okay. You could do a Doc Cheatham.

MR: I know what you mean.

CJ: I don't want to play older music. I want to play newer music when I'm older.

MR: Wow. That's a strong statement.

CJ: Well, and I want to play well. I don't want to play okay. And trumpets are very physical athletic sort of things. So that may dictate how long I play. Snooky didn't hear very well in his last years — he didn't hear very well and that hampered his playing a bit, but he still played very well.

MR: That's the same with Joe I think. He had the hearing aid thing, but he certainly had a marvelous conception.

CJ: Yeah. I met him and he was playing with the Carnegie — no, no, — he was playing with the Smithsonian. And I met him in Europe one time. Snooky introduced me to him. What a gentleman he was, wow. What a marvelous guy.

MR: This could be a hard question, but why — I would assume the position at Eastman, that you have, was a fairly competitive — I mean it's a respected university throughout the world. So why did they pick you, do you think, as opposed to someone else?

CJ: I don't know. I felt very lucky. I knew a few people there, that didn't hurt. And I knew Fred Sturm who had been the head of the department there. I really was a fan of Harold Danko's, who is the piano teacher still there. I had heard him with Thad Jones who was one of my favorites. So when I heard that — they called me. I didn't know about the job. But I went and interviewed along with four other guys. So I felt pretty good about it. But it was a little bit of a rude awakening once I got there. I wasn't really prepared when I got there in terms of being a teacher at Eastman. I'd taught a lot but I wasn't as organized as I should have been.

MR: Organization is a big part of it.

CJ: It is.

MR: But where were you with the theoretical part of teaching jazz?

CJ: I was in a pretty good place with that. I'd been teaching a lot at some of the schools in Los Angeles — at USC and Cal Arts and I taught at a school called the Colburn School which is more of a classical school, and in terms of — well I don't think you're talking specifically like music theory, but I have a degree in music theory and so the theoretical, like harmony, like very specific harmony things, I was pretty good, I was pretty informed. But I've become a lot more informed. I realized how uninformed I was being at Eastman. Because my colleagues like Bill Dobbins and Jeff Campbell and Danko and there's another guy called Dariusz Terefenko who — they're just really informed. So I was pretty well informed but I think I had gotten much much more in depth with it, and that's something I pass on to my students, really going for depth. Because I needed to go

MR: Okay I want you to think back — well I'm not sure when this would be — but did you have a specific moment or moments of inspiration that led you down the jazz path?

CJ: Yes. My family was pretty musical and my father played — not professionally but he was a good kind of part time Dixieland trumpet player and he really loved it. And at one time, it was really a moment for me, I was a kid and when he took us to Disneyland — we lived in Texas but we were in California. We went to Disneyland and Stan Kenton's band was playing. And I was amazed how happy people seemed. And it seemed like heavenly. Everybody was dancing and laughing and talking. And it just seemed like wow, this music's really making these people happy. And I was a little kid. And then he took me to a place called Shelly's Manne-Hole when I was a kid, and heard Milton Jackson, I heard the MJQ, the Modern Jazz Quartet, Ray Brown was playing. And that was pretty amazing. I was just a little kid. But it was just amazing how I felt like the music made people feel better. So I think that's what kind of got me on to it. And then I became a musician and I liked how you could make mistakes in jazz and it wasn't the end of the world. Whereas if I made a mistake on the Haydn Trumpet Concerto, oh my gracious, what next — when's the next one coming? And so I really liked that, not having to worry about so many mistakes.

MR: And that the audience didn't hear them like they would hear them in a Haydn Trumpet Concerto.

CJ: Yes. Because I didn't hear Milt Jackson making mistakes. And he seemed to be having such a great time. And I'll tell you something else. I liked — I was brought up in West Texas and it wasn't a very diverse area racially, but my dad and mom were very open about that, about the beauty of difference in races. And I loved being around African-American people. My dad had some African-American — and I loved that and I loved hearing guys play together and I saw what great friends they were. And I hadn't seen that before. And I've always loved that. And I experienced that with Basie, and I experience that now with the Clayton-Hamilton band. Because that's a very — for lack of a better word — mixed band, and we're all really, like we're like brothers. And I love that. I love that.

MR: Yeah. The Kenton band was not like that was it?

CJ: No, it wasn't. Not by design necessarily, but Woody and Stan and even Buddy Rich, they were pretty white bands. Not by design necessarily. Stan had a couple of African-American guys in the band, but it was a pretty white band.

MR: Do you think that black players would not be attracted that much to what Stan Kenton did?

CJ: Possibly. Because we called it kind of Wagnerian jazz you know. And I loved it. And

But it was kind of heavy. It swung in its own way but certainly it was a different kind of swing than Bas'. But I don't think the guys, like on Basie's band, they were very respectful of it on Stan's band, but it was sort of — it wasn't a band — it seemed like it was sort of a whiter band, sort of like Woody.

MR: Okay. Yeah, you had said, I had read something about you liked to go off with your mistakes, so I got a whole CD of your mistakes we'll listen to — just kidding.

CJ: My mistakes.

MR: I'm going to backtrack a little bit. You talked about when you got to Eastman you needed to bone up on your theory some, and get more informed about that. Do you think it changed the way you improvised?

CJ: Yes, I feel it's continuing to. I just, I sort of consider myself an ear player to a degree, but I want to be an informed ear player. I mean so I know the changes of songs, and I don't play tunes I don't know, and I know a lot of songs. And I can play piano well enough to comp for my students. So my colleagues are very informed, like Bill Dobbins, and Harold, and Dariusz and Jeff. Jeff is the bass teacher. But they're very informed. I'm sort of probably the loose cannon of the bunch in terms of theory. I'm not quite as literal as them maybe. But piano players maybe are more literal. I don't know. But they're all different too, all three of those guys. But my ears got better I think, having been at Eastman for 16 years. And I've decided I'm paying more close attention to details, especially when I'm practicing. And then when I go to play I think it comes out better. Even though I go against the grain harmonically quite a lot. I do think it's better for me to know those details better.

MR: When you go against the grain, which I like that term, do you make a specific choice, what's that going to be? I'm not sure I can be specific about it. If it's a C9 chord are there formulas to go against the grain with that?

CJ: Yes, to a degree. But mine's more — a little bit more serendipitous. To me it's not chord by chord, it's more contextual. Like I tell my students, and I try to be myself too, is more compositional improvisationally. So using the melody of the tune might steer me in a different way musically than following the changes per se, and it might go against the grain that way. And to me the melody kind of trumps the changes at that point. So some people might not agree with that. I'm sure they don't. Some people may think that I'm not following them close enough. So I definitely — it's all relative. Because sometimes people have said to me, like when I used to do recording sessions in Los Angeles people would say, "this needs to be like right down the middle." And I'd play what I thought was right down the middle and they'd say, "well that's not what we were looking for."

MR: This was on people's jazz dates?

CJ: Yeah. So different people have — you know I've had people come up and say, "you know I didn't write a sharp nine on that chord." I'm sorry. But some of it's sort of serendipitous too, I must say. Sometimes I'll try something just to see if it might stick. And it depends on the context. Like if I was called in out there in Los Angeles to record a solo over something else, a lot of times I'd just say, "what are you hearing?" Maybe, "why don't you sing me something that you're hearing." Because I wanted to please. It wasn't my time to be an artist. It was more my time to be a craftsman sometimes. So I learned that the hard way a few times. But if it's like on my record, or if people call me to play on a record and the music's very adventuresome then they usually let me play the way I play. Like I play a lot with this great drummer, actually originally from Rochester, Joe LaBarbera. Joe never tells me how to play. You know? Joe likes the way I play. And I love playing with him. Now on the Clayton-Hamilton band, I've been on that band for 30 years. And there was a time when I probably wasn't fitting in as well, I think probably because I wasn't as good a blues player as I needed to be. And that's something I had to revisit, I still do. But now that I'm a better blues player I feel like they just know my voice is going to fit in certain situations, and in certain situations maybe not. But John is very respectful of me, the way I play.

MR: How do you revisit the blues?

CJ: I realized — are you familiar with the Clayton-Hamilton Jazz Orchestra?

MR: Um hum.

CJ: That's such a great band, and I realized one day that I wasn't the blues player that I needed to be to really play that band right. I played okay, but I wasn't a great blues player and I feel like every jazz musician has to be a good blues player. So I put it upon myself to be more informed and be a better blues player and maybe study where it came from. And one of the things I went to was the Mississippi Delta guys, like Son House and Robert Johnson and those guys, and I really dove into that. And I got to where I really loved it. It was a little hard to listen to at first, and then I just got into it. You know, Muddy Waters — and so I realized that it made me a better blues player in terms of gestures and in terms of form of the blues and in terms of nuance, and I realized I should be playing the blues every time I play a solo. That's what I learned from the Clayton band. For me it has to have those elements of the blues: form and nuance and the blues gestures. So that to me made me a better jazz player, being a better blues player. Not that I'm where I want to be yet, at all, as a blues player. I still really am studying it.

MR: I love that statement you just made, being a better jazz player through being a better blues player. I know what you mean when you listen to Son House and Charley Patton and all that, it takes a while to understand that. At first I remember thinking well they just played

CJ: And there's only three beats in that bar.

MR: Yeah. Like you have to get over that.

CJ: Exactly. But it's just so heartfelt and the nuance was so amazing. And they were living that and — I introduced some of my young trumpet players at Eastman to some of this stuff and I had this kid come up to me and he said, "I don't like this stuff but I sure am glad you're playing it for me." And I thought man, I was the same way. But I mean it's not the beginning of the blues certainly. Because that was in the 30s when those guys were — you know. And then Muddy Waters kind of took that to Chicago and then that was another thing with electric guitars and everything. But that Delta thing just really hit home with me, and I feel like it made me a little bit more — it had more validity as a player. I'm very interested in African-American culture anyway. I always have been. And that was sort of the heart of the south in a really rough time. And so much of our music, whether it be country-western or blues or jazz or pop or R&B, it's all got that in it. So it's such a common denominator in American music, the essence of the blues. It's so important. We wouldn't have music if it wasn't for that.

MR: I forget how many times I've read this quote that goes something like, "jazz is America's only true art form." And I always say, "what about the blues?"

CJ: Well it came from the blues. It came from the blues. Yeah.

MR: The other interesting thing for a horn player if you go to blues jam sessions, you'd better be ready to play in some tougher keys.

CJ: That's right. Guitars. You better be. I make my students, you know we play the blues in every key every day, just on your own with a metronome. Be able to play what you're hearing and make — and it's also, you know — when I was younger I would play — I was okay, but I didn't make that statement like what we call kind of the A-A-B or the consequent phrase. Like so many blues songs, "I left my baby and don't know what to do" with a period there. And then for a chance for the listener to absorb it. And the next four bars on the four chord, the same thing. We that aren't so steeped in the blues, we need to be taught that. And so I really bug my students about that. Because they'll play the blues and they're playing all this vocabulary and I'm like, "I've got to hear that thing."

MR: I have a neat thing with Clark Terry and Joe Williams talking about THE blue notes.

CJ: Yeah. Those worried notes. Oh yeah. Well that's all in the gesture too. And the nuance. Yeah. And those guys and the Delta guys, they didn't know the third and the flatted third and all that. So it was nuanced. It was worrying that stuff. That's the way a friend of mine described it. Worrying the third, worrying the fifth. Yeah. It's really important.

MR: Yeah. I take you back to Los Angeles and you did some studio work. Was that fairly high

CJ: Yeah. Well it depends on what you're doing. If we're sitting in a 40-piece orchestra and somebody's going to clam a whole note, that would be Clam Jenkins, right here. I'd be the one to make that mistake. Because I would just get so nervous sitting in these movie date sessions. I had some really good opportunities. And it was sort of a blessing in a way because I had some really great opportunities to be a pretty good studio player and I just didn't have the mindset for it. So I didn't end up doing that. And I'm thankful now because I'm a jazz musician. So when I go and do jazz records, I'm not that nervous about it. So it depended you know. Because out there the thing was to not make a mistake. And I'm just not that good at that.

MR: And you probably wouldn't see the music until you got there?

CJ: Oh no. Very seldom, which made me nervous too. Oh my gosh. And every once in a while you'd get there and looking at it and, oh, I wish I could have seen this thing. And those guys out there are so good at that. They're great. They're just like masters at sight reading stuff the first time, playing it down, no mistakes, out the door, because they have a ten o'clock. So yeah they're fantastic musicians. But it just wasn't my thing. And it paid really well. Because once you did that thing you'd get re-use and all that stuff. And for a commercial you could make thousands of dollars for an hour. And guys were clamoring over each other to get those jobs. And they were great at it. I do admire them so much. But that just wasn't my thing.

MR: Do you still get an occasional check in the mail?

CJ: Oh I do.

MR: Can you tell me something that you might hear that you'd go, "oh I was on that."

CJ: Oh I was on a movie called "Bull Durham." Baseball movie. And it was just me. And it was just in one scene. And I must have played that thing 40 times. I remember the guy's name was Michael Convertino. He was the composer. And it was just trumpet. That's all it was. Maybe with synthesizer or something. It was just a kind of a dramatic scene in the locker room. And I've made so much money off that thing. And I didn't play that many. But I just was lucky to get called for it. I mean I'm on some movies and stuff. But that's not my pride really. I love playing on records. I've played on probably a hundred records or more, which sounds maybe like a lot but when you talk about Snooky Young or Joe Wilder, Snooky played on a thousand records.

MR: That used to be a hobby of mine with LPs, sort of like, "oh there he is again."

CJ: "There he is again."

MR: And you'd see these guys move from one thing to another.

CJ: Oh yeah. Especially in New York. Snooky said he'd have like four sessions a day sometimes. You know? He wouldn't even go home. He'd just get a hotel room. Because

Because he'd do "The Tonight Show," and he'd have so many great things. I mean he played on so many great records. And he deserved every second of it. But that's what I like doing. I like playing on records.

MR: Did you learn from listening to guys like him how to play lead?

CJ: Oh well any trumpet player worth his salt would say Snooky Young is the father of lead trumpet playing. There's no question about it. I mean I learned that a long time before I met Snooky Young. When I went to North Texas State University one of my teacher's name was Jay Saunders, a great trumpet player there. He's the one that got me on Kenton's band. And we're still really good friends. My son's named after Jay. But he sat me down and he said, "this is Snooky Young and that is the way you play lead trumpet. And that's that." You know? And it was a totally different style. Jay had played with Kenton and the Kenton style was totally different than Snooks. Because vibrato and shakes and everything was different.

MR: How about playing the time? Was that different?

CJ: Well on Basie's band yeah, it was definitely different. But playing the time in terms of the lead trumpet player connecting with the drummer, Snooky was the prince of that. And he was so amazing with that. And he played with all these great drummers like Sonny Payne and Jo Jones and Mel Lewis and Jeff Hamilton and Ed Shaughnessy and all these great drummers. And he played lead. And that just made the band — that connection between lead trumpet and drums was unbelievable. And he'd come right out and say, "that's who I'm listening to." And everybody knew it. So it made the band swing. Because if you're hooking up with Snooky, and he's hooking up with the drummer, everything's okay. Because Snooky played lead on the Clayton band for a long time. And then he played second and then he wanted me to play — and then I played second. Because as he got older he didn't want to play all that high stuff. But he had unbelievable high chops. So it was very effortless for him. He just had unbelievably consistent high chops.

MR: I have this wonderful moment with him talking with Gerald Wilson and they were talking about going from the Lunceford band —

CJ: Right, they left the same day.

MR: And went to the Basie band, and Snooky said, "I had to learn how to play all over."

CJ: That's right he told me that too. Because he said Lunceford's band was like a show band kind of two-beat band. And Basie was in four swinging. And he said a few times, he said, "I'm not making this." And the guys in Basie's band said, "yes, Snooky, you're doing okay." Marshall Royal said, "yeah, you're doing okay." And Snooky said, "I'm not making it." He said, "yeah, yeah, yeah, you are." He told me that several times. And he's

him is what got the dynamic of the band. The accents where he put the accents, that was the dynamic of the band, and everything else was softer. So the accents made it dance and swing and bounce. And to me, and I think I'm right about this, I'm not very dogmatic about very many things, but he was on the band with Lester Young. And early on he knew Lester Young, he knew Billie Holliday, he knew all those people. And the band went through Kansas City well who was listening to Lester Young? Charlie Parker. And so to me Lester Young's style and the Basie style is what influenced the bop style. Accents on the upbeat. And that thing that just made it dance. Where the swing band beforehand that the accents had been on the downbeat. Like Benny Goodman and even players like Coleman Hawkins and Ben — it was on the downbeat. But Basie's band it was like dancing. And I just think that was so incredibly important. So I give a lot of credit to Snooky.

MR: Boy that stuff, how do you point to one person, from what you're describing, that feel, that offbeat thing.

CJ: Yeah.

MR: Who's responsible for that?

CJ: Well I think really it's the rhythm section and they were kind of — the way that Basie played. Because he was really a great player. He was really like [scats]. I don't know if boogaloo is the right word, but just a jump.

MR: Shuffley?

CJ: Yeah, yeah. Like a jump band. I really think it came from the rhythm section [scats] that kind of stuff. So the upbeat [scats]. Which is much more modern swing. That's the way we still play. And people, if they have trouble with that, they have trouble with it. It's the weirdest thing. And being around Snooky — one time my wife said, "you can never leave the Clayton band because you play the way you play because you sat next to Snooky Young all those years." And it's true. And I mean we solo totally different. When Snooky soloed he was more downbeat. But when he played lead oh my gracious. There was nothing like playing in a section with Snooky Young playing lead. There was nothing like it. So he's definitely the father of that. And really I think if you asked anybody, Jon Faddis or any trumpet player, or Byron Stripling or anybody like that, they'd say no, Snooky Young. Yeah definitely.

MR: Well sort of a connected question, what do you like to get from a bass player?

CJ: Interesting question. Because a lot of my very very best friends are bass players. Yeah because I really love bass. One of my best friends, Jeff Campbell at the Eastman School is beautiful bass player. But I've known guys, well John Clayton is a great bass player and he's one of my heroes and a guy named Bob Bowman in Kansas City a guy that I

George Anderson — all these guys were bass players. So I guess just a big beat and someone you can really trust in terms of the time and the form. Because there's so much, especially in more modern music there's so much responsibility to a bass player. Because he's really in charge — to me he's in charge of the beat and he's in charge of the harmony, which means he's in charge of the form. Like Rufus Reid, when he's playing, he's in charge of the rhythm section you know? So he wouldn't say that, but he is. So that's kind of, I love, and there's the roots, and I love bass players. I do a lot of playing with chordless trios, with just bass and drums. And I just like a big beat and I love it when they're so trustworthy in terms of the form.

MR: Very interesting. Like most musicians, I'm guessing you have a list, under all instruments you have your list. I'm going to say this question from a backwards standpoint. What gets people less likely to be called by you? What makes a musician sort of move down your list as far as filling a gig?

CJ: Well if they're not a nice person. If they're not a nice person I usually don't — we've got to get along. I mean I know some really great players I wouldn't call because they don't strike me as nice men or women. That would be the first thing. I don't like it when piano players comp too much. I like it when they don't comp very much. Harold Danko is a fantastic comper and he doesn't comp very much at all. I mean sometimes when he does you don't notice it because he's just very economical.

MR: I'm glad to hear you say that because I think sometimes musicians in small groups don't realize that, especially for piano or guitar, by not playing they're adding a texture.

CJ: Right.

MR: The silence is a sound.

CJ: That's a great point, yeah. Harold Danko told me a great thing. He said he was playing in New York and he did three nights at The Kitano. And he said there was a very well-dressed gentleman there all three nights and at the end of the third night the guy walked up to him and said, "I'm not a musician, I'm a doctor." And Harold said, "well it's nice to meet you." And he said, "I've got to tell you," he said, "but if I was a piano player I'd like to know how to lay out just like you." I thought that was great. You're right. By not playing they're adding a texture. You're so right. And another thing I tell my guys, you know there's something about a trio — there's something very special about a trio that's the art of the trio. But there's something special about a trio. If a horn player's playing with a group and everybody's playing then he doesn't get a trio. So I like it when piano players don't play because then I get a trio. I like having a trio. Because there's very special nuance and magic that happens with a trio. So when a piano player doesn't play or the guitar player doesn't play then I've got the — or if the drummer doesn't play. But

piano players tend not to do that. You know? So I really encourage them to get out of there.

MR: Do you actually suggest that to them sometimes?

CJ: I do to my students.

MR: Well if no one's ever told them — I think it's so obvious that people don't actually think of it. Like it's more like it's wrong to not play. Like gee I'm not playing, this isn't right.

CJ: Well I've had students like get mad at me for telling them to lay out. Even if the guitar player's comping, some piano players want to comp too. So yeah that's a great point.

MR: Well do you remember, in *Down Beat* magazine they used to do the blindfold test?

CJ: Yes.

MR: Okay. Well I have a couple for you. But I don't think they're —

[audio interlude "Clifford Brown with Strings"]

CJ: Sounds sort of like Clifford to me.

MR: Yes indeed. This is his — I think they're going to be coming in any minute now.

CJ: The strings. Yeah.

MR: You like Clifford Brown?

CJ: Oh man yeah. What a gentleman he was. And in studying him I think we realized he wasn't as steeped in some of the bop traditions as some of the other guys like Kenny Dorham or something like that, in terms of harmony. But he was just such a beautiful player. He's what I think of as being more of a diatonic player. And some guys would disagree with me on that. But he didn't get in the cracks as much as like K.D. or even early Miles or Dizzy or Fats, even though Fats was a huge influence to Clifford. Huge. If you listen to Fats records, Fats Navarro records, a lot of times you'd swear it's Clifford. But yeah, but he was just such a beautiful player. He played with such a sound. He was a very giving player.

MR: Okay here's another one.

[audio interlude]

CJ: Ah, that's me. What is that on? Oh that's —

MR: Beautiful.

CJ: I forget what record that's on.

MR: It's called "Azure Eyes."

CJ: "Azure Eyes," yeah. That's the title track of that. That's what I thought it was.

MR: I love sort of aggressive articulation even when playing a ballad. And I think I heard that, and with Clifford too. [scats] Like you don't have to just mumble everything even if you're playing a ballad.

CJ: Yeah. That's interesting. I agree with you. You know one of my influences was a guy

beautiful player and we are good friends, even though I don't get to see him very often. But Tim is very aggressive. And those are big shoes to fill when I got on Kenton's band. He went on to other things. And I think I got some of that aggressive articulation from him a bit. In fact there was a time when I had to kind of say, "I've got to stop sounding so much like Tim Hagans." I mean he had a record come out years later and a friend of mine came up and said, "I heard a guy play and he sounds just like you." And Tim had sent me this record and I said, "no, that's not what's going on there." I said, "I sound like him." And I was right. Yeah. He's a great player. Tim Hagans.

MR: Okay. Here's — this actually starts with some piano.

[audio interlude]

CJ: Gosh. Is that Joe LaBarbera?

MR: Yes.

CJ: Yeah. That was probably Bill Cunliffe on piano.

MR: Yeah. So I wanted to ask you about what happened there. Because of course in the whole recording there's the head and then I think the sax player plays.

CJ: Uh huh. Bob Sheppard.

MR: Bob Sheppard. Then there's this piano solo. And it gets pretty intense. And then you come in and there's a lot of space. And I'm wondering, I was thinking how deliberate and how preplanned was that?

CJ: I wouldn't say preplanned at all, because I always leave a lot of space. I've had people say, "man I like the way you leave space." Sometimes if they compliment me it's because of the space I leave. Pete Erskine said that to me one time, he said, "I like how you leave space." So to me it just helps me listen to them and maybe I can kind of — not that I want them to copy me or mark me or anything like that, but it also gives me ideas when I leave space. Like with Joe, Joe never repeats what I play but it's just like a momentum gathering thing to leave space with Joe. Because he's such a fantastic drummer. And I've always left a lot of space. And I leave more space than a lot of guys — and I try to get my students to leave space. Now sometimes, with some players, space is long notes. Like with Trane or with Rich Perry. He's another tenor player who I love. Rich Perry is one of my favorite tenor players. Rich doesn't leave a ton of space but his space is long notes. So that's when things start churning. But for me I like to leave big gaping holes of space.

MR: Well it gives you somewhere to go too.

CJ: It does. Yeah. And it makes me listen. Yeah.

MR: And I felt like for that particular recording that the other players were sort of responding to you. Like the piano player sort of laid out for a while, like I'm not going to mess with what he's doing too much, the best thing I can do is not play for the time being.

CJ: And he knows I will travel far and wide to get to play with Joe LaBarbera. Because Joe is one of the most amazing people, and amazing drummer. And he loves to play. And he makes people play better, which is the biggest compliment I can say for anybody. I've gotten to play with some really great drummers. He and Jeff Hamilton and Dennis Mackrel and Steve Houghton, and all these great drummers I've gotten to play with. The guy at Eastman, Rich Thompson. They make you play better. Joe is amazing.

MR: Where does he live now?

CJ: Joe is out in Los Angeles.

MR: Okay. Here's one last thing. This is just a personal favorite.

[audio interlude]

CJ: Oh that's Nat. Oh.

MR: Talk about playing the blues.

CJ: Oh I love Nat Adderley. Well one person — it kind of gave it away because I knew it was Cannonball, but I'm a huge, like one of my — that's cornet — I'm a huge Nat Adderley fan. Oh I love Nat Adderley. You know we talk about our desert island records, the record that Cannonball and Nancy Wilson did.

MR: Oh I can't believe you said that.

CJ: I mean Nat — Nat's all over that thing. Nat Adderley is one of the most underrated trumpet players. He was so funky and swinging and he had great chops and a great sound. But every note was swinging. Oh man I'm a huge fan of Nat Adderley.

MR: That's my favorite record.

CJ: Oh I love that record. That's a fantastic record. Oh. I got to ask Nancy Wilson about that one time because she was singing with the Clayton band and I had a moment, it was just a gift, I said I want to ask you about it. And she said, "yeah, people ask me about that all the time." I said, "was that just so fun?" And she said, "oh, Zawinul and, what a band." You know.

MR: And the little arrangements they had behind her. I'm a big, basically both of them, Adderley nut. And I used to think when I would listen to their stuff a lot of times they would do a lot of stuff in unison. And I always thought boy if I was arranging that I would have done a harmony. Well that's why they're who they are. They sort of knew that. It sounded like one voice.

CJ: Yeah. And you'd go to see them and there was a high mic and a low mic. And Cannonball would play on the high mic, and Nat, who was much smaller, would play on the low mic. Right? Oh man, yeah, I'm a huge fan. You know we were talking about Gene Bertoncini who is a huge fan. He got to do a record with Nancy Wilson, it's called "But Beautiful." And it was Gene and Hank Jones and I think Ron Carter and Grady Tate

here or there. The tunes are super short. And they finished it and they were going to add strings and they listened to it and they decided not to because it's just so great. And that was such a credit to Gene that he got to do that kind of stuff and he was such a great accompanist and such a great player.

MR: Okay. Jazz in academia. Every once in a while your favorite topic — it seems to, every couple of years I think some critic will write jazz is dead. You know the jazz is dead article. And they cite the abysmal record sales and the club scene. But on the other hand, you have jazz in almost every academic institution in the country and you go to Jazz Education Network, those conferences, and do you have a sort of a perspective on the state of jazz?

CJ: Yeah. I mean kids that spend a lot of money in jazz school, I'm kind of torn about that because there's not a lot of work. It's a really hard living. It's really hard to make a living just playing. And so kids kind of write and play, or write, play and teach. And now they're talking about, at Eastman we're starting to talk about having classes to write music for games and that kind of stuff. So I mean just finding ways to be more versatile. On the other hand, my kids, and I have lovely, lovely people as students, they're just the best, they're great kids. They're very respectful. And they're very respectful of the legacy and then they bring in this new stuff. And lately the stuff they've been bringing in, I just love the stuff they've been bringing in. Years ago some of it felt like sort of self-involved and hard to understand. They were real hard meters and it was hard to play. And we needed that. Because now the meters don't sound so hard, the odd meters, and our kids, especially just this year, they've brought in stuff and played for me and I just, wow, I really like it and it's been really inspirational. So I don't know where it's going in terms of the business, but I certainly think it's growing in terms of the players. Because all I know is my students but they're very respectful of the legacy. They never say, "I don't want to play 'Gone with the Wind.'" They're all about that stuff. And I have them study older players like Louis Armstrong and Sweets, and I tell them I don't want you to necessarily play like that but I want you to have them in your playing. That's the way we approach it. Professionally every once in a while for a recording session they may be called on to play just like Sweets Edison and that'll pay off. But that's not the essence of what I'm trying to do. I'm trying to get Sweets Edison in their playing. Because he wasn't in mine at first. That was a hole I had to fill. So my students have been so respectful of that, but then surging ahead and they learn really fast. They're so far ahead of where I was when I was their age. It's not even funny. They're so far ahead. I couldn't play like my kids play when I was a junior in college. Nowhere close. I couldn't play the way some of them play when I was out on the road with Kenton. Nowhere close. They

— they're playing really hard music really well. So I think the music can't do anything but grow and germinate and be better. I'm not pessimistic about it. The business, yes. But they'll find a way. Because they were saying that when I was coming out of college. "Oh yeah, you're not going to make a living doing that." But I've had a very nice career of it.

MR: Do you require them to memorize a certain number of standards?

CJ: Yeah. I'm kind of a numbers guy. I like my students to know a lot of tunes. I shoot for a hundred. And that's a lot. And some of my colleagues say that seems like a — but I've learned, as a horn player, when you know some obscure Monk tune and somebody calls their favorite Monk tune and you know it, you're in the club. And so it really pays off to know, not just harmonies but like — like you might know eight "I Got Rhythm" tunes. But if a guy wants to play "Moose the Mooche" then you've got to know the head to "Moose the Mooche." You know? And especially Bird tunes and Monk tunes. I'm a real — I'm very strict about it and I bug my students to really get in there and learn those. Because it's really paid off for me in terms of work. So yeah, and plus they need to learn how to learn those tunes. Because when they go and learn hard original tunes they're going to have to play them and they're going to have to know how to learn them. And I think they learn how to learn that by learning standards. And these kids are smart and they really learn fast. I've got a kid at Eastman now, Christian Crawford is his name. And I assigned that Bird tune "Quasimodo," which is a tune on "Embraceable You." He learned it in a week. That tune took me a month to learn that tune and I was really working on it. He learned it in a week. So they know that's just my thing. But the long answer to your question, yes I really require them learning tunes. A lot of standards. And not just the regular ones.

MR: Not just "Blue Bossa."

CJ: No.

MR: Do the jazz students at Eastman, even the faculty, do you feel like more of a clannish clique at Eastman? Are you separate from the classical world or not?

CJ: No. I'm going to say that's one thing I love about Eastman is generally speaking no. The other trumpet teacher there is one of the — the classical trumpet teacher there, the main guy, is one of the best trumpet players I've ever heard in my life. His name is Jim Thompson. He is so respectful of the jazz. Now that's not always the case in schools. But Jim is so respectful to me and of the jazz thing. And he's not a jazz player whatsoever. So I think in some schools it is an issue. It definitely is. Like oh you can't play in the big band because you have a recital this semester, and that kind of stuff. Jim would never say that. He couldn't care less.

MR: So some players do both.

CJ: Oh sure. And sometimes the jazz guys are a little bit better versed at playing in a brass quintet than the brass quintet guys are, because of style more than anything. So that's something that we work on. And I give studio classes with his students all the time. Because he's of the opinion that in the future, and I agree with him, in the future a symphonic trumpet section might consist of a principal player and then a second player, and then a guy that can play lead on some pop stuff, and then a guy that can stand up and play changes and not sound silly, as well as be a good fourth trumpet player in a symphony. I mean that's smart.

MR: Yes it is.

CJ: It's very smart.

MR: Because students still do the classical path first.

CJ: Sure. Especially on certain instruments like trumpet. I think that's important. Because you need to be a good classical player to be a good jazz player. Otherwise that horn's going to get in your way. Now other instruments not so much. Drummers don't have to be great mallet players or guitar players might not need to have classical chops necessarily. I don't know. I don't want to speak for them. Bass players I think need to have good arco/bowing technique. They need to have good classical technique. And it's tried and true technique. John Clayton's a beautiful classical player. Jeff Campbell, the jazz teacher at Eastman, he's in the RPO. He's a beautiful player. And you can hear it in his pitch and his dexterity and articulation. You can hear that he's a really great bass player. And he got that from being a good classical player. So yeah, I think we need to go through that. And that's another thing I like about Eastman is that the kids have to pass — like the piano players, they have to pass some classical barriers. They just do. That's just part of it. So that's the thing I love about it. Now I'm sure there are faculty at Eastman that, "ah, they're jazzers." But generally, and the administration is incredibly supportive of the jazz department. So that's one thing I actually like about it, more so than other schools.

MR: I got to play, when I was in high school in Rochester, Chuck Mangione led — it was sort of an all-county thing.

CJ: Oh cool.

MR: And this was before he became — I wonder if he's — does he have a legacy at Eastman of a sort?

CJ: To a degree. Yeah. I think so. We're respectful of him. I don't really know him. But he had a hand in getting things going I think. I do. And his brother Gap. No you can't take that away. And he played — Chuck Mangione played with Blakey.

MR: And Cannonball discovered them — the jazz brothers. Cannonball brought them into

CJ: Yeah. He did the pop thing and all that but he definitely was a part of the Eastman jazz legacy.

MR: Well is there anything that I haven't asked you that you'd like to offer?

CJ: I'm just honored to be here and thankful for people like you that care enough about this stuff — because I'm not a huge name and I'm just humbled by all these pictures and the fact that you are doing this. It's amazing to me. And you're studied and you're prepared and you're respectful. We all so appreciate people like you.

MR: Well thanks. On the gig tonight, do you get to call the tunes?

CJ: Well I sent several of the things I do, some of them are obscure Bird and Monk tunes. And Mike Dubaniewicz, who was a student of ours at Eastman, and I sent him a few of my originals and he was great. He rehearsed the band and he set up two sets for tonight and he kind of picked out of the stuff I sent. Because I left it up to him because he knows his guys and then we're going to do a couple of arrangements of his. So indirectly yes, but I left it up to him for what he would be comfortable with. I sent some stuff that was not very hard, and he set up two great sets. So I think it will be a lot of fun.

MR: Yeah. It should be. Well thanks for your time today.

CJ: My pleasure. Thank you.

MR: A pleasure for me.